## JINXED CHAIR



Telangana **CM Revanth Reddy** had a pointed good luck message for the new Union education minister, saying he hoped Pralhad Joshi would be able to avoid the fate of his predecessors who had occupied the ministry since 2014. "Smriti Irani, Prakash Javadekar, Dharmendra Pradhan... *lagta hai jo bhi us kursi par baithta hai, uski political kismat kharab ho jaati hai* (looks like whoever occupies that chair, his political fortunes dip)," Revanth quipped last week. Indeed, it looks like Joshi may need all the good wishes he can get for his onward journey.

## BROTHERS IN ARMS



For some time now, Lalu Yadav's sons **Tejashwi** and **Tej Pratap** have been on divergent paths, their public differences making any reconciliation seem unlikely. But Bihar's politics often produces unexpected turns. Returning to Patna on July 26 after a long absence, Opposition leader and Rashtriya Janata Dal chief Tejashwi demanded the release of those arrested during the paper leak protests, which pointedly included "*mere bade bhai* Tej Pratap" (who had allegedly been inciting the protesters). The elder Yadav scion's adventures may have landed him in jail, but they also seem to have restored some fraternal warmth.

## A GEN Z MOMENT



It was a classic family WhatsApp moment, only this one unfolded on Instagram. Archita Sachin Rahar, daughter of BJP MP from Bhubaneswar, **Aparajita Sarangi**, posted a celebratory reaction to the Union minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation over the NEET leak controversy, adding that she was sure someone would push her mother to get the post removed. "Don't bother. I won't delete it," she wrote. Meanwhile, Sarangi praised Pradhan's 'courage' on X, while her office was busy defending Archita's right to speak, as part of "Gen Z". Sources say top BJP leaders were least amused with the hullabaloo the social media chats created.

**Kaushik Deka *with* Ashish Misra, Ajay Sukumaran, Prasad Nichenametla, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar *and* Amitabh Srivastava**

ECO WATCH

## GIR LION ATTACKS
## A PROBLEM OF PLENTY

*By* **Jumana Shah**

Gujarat's conservation triumph with the Asiatic Lions is straining against its own success. Six deaths due to lion attacks in June and July have shaken up the Saurashtra peninsula. The most shocking of these was the death of an 11-year-old boy, dragged away while the family was climbing the steps to the temples atop Mount Girnar. The outrage is testing the foundations of the state's celebrated conservation model—of humans and lions sharing spaces and coexisting.



Such unprovoked attacks were unusual in the past. The 2025 census counted 891 Asiatic lions, up from 674 five years earlier. Only 384 live inside protected forests. The remaining 507, or 44.2 per cent, now range across the 30,000 sq. km Greater Gir landscape. Officials and experts point to several converging pressures—rising lion numbers, habitat pressure, thinning ungulate population.... "Furthermore, humans are moving into lion territory with illegal resorts and other activities in protected areas. This is a recipe for disaster," says photographer Bhushan Pandya, a former member of the state wildlife board. Disease has sharpened the alarm. In May, eight lions died, officially of babesiosis. Reliable sources, though, claim some of them were infected with canine distemper virus (CDV), and that the toll was higher.

After the uproar, the forest department captured 30-plus lions and declared seven of them 'maneaters'. But there are no easy solutions. The recent incidents have attracted international attention to Gir on the one hand, while on the other, leaders of the ruling party have clashed with the forest department for putting curbs on development work in the region.